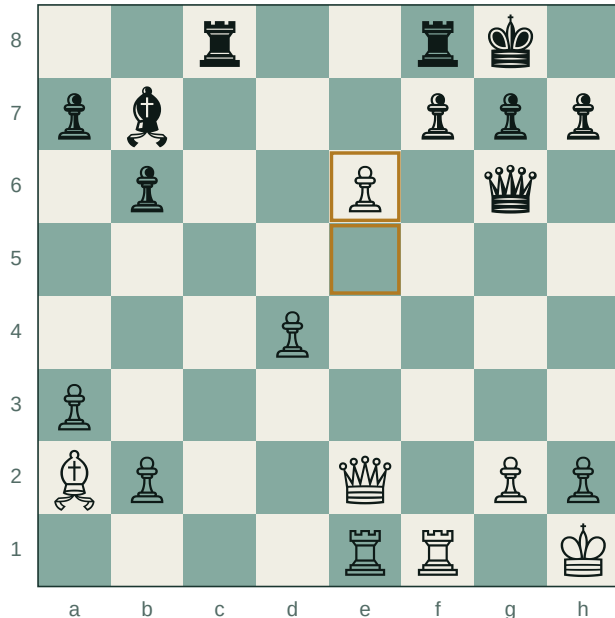


Active defensive resources: Black, move 21

Active defensive resources

Black to move



Previous move: 21.e6. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

21...Rc2 22. exf7+ Kh8

21...Rc2 The rook moves from c8 to c2. Recorded reply: **22.exf7+**.

22...Kh8 The king moves from g8 to h8.

At the end, nominal material is White 28 / Black 26 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from -1 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

A defensive puzzle may aim to preserve equality rather than win. Judge success against the threat, not only the final material count.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

The best defense may create a threat, exchange an attacker, or change the geometry of the attack. Identify the opponent's concrete idea before selecting a response.

HOW TO LOOK

Name the threatened move and the conditions it requires. Look for a move that breaks one of those conditions with tempo.

The defending king is on h1. Absolute pin: pawn on g2.